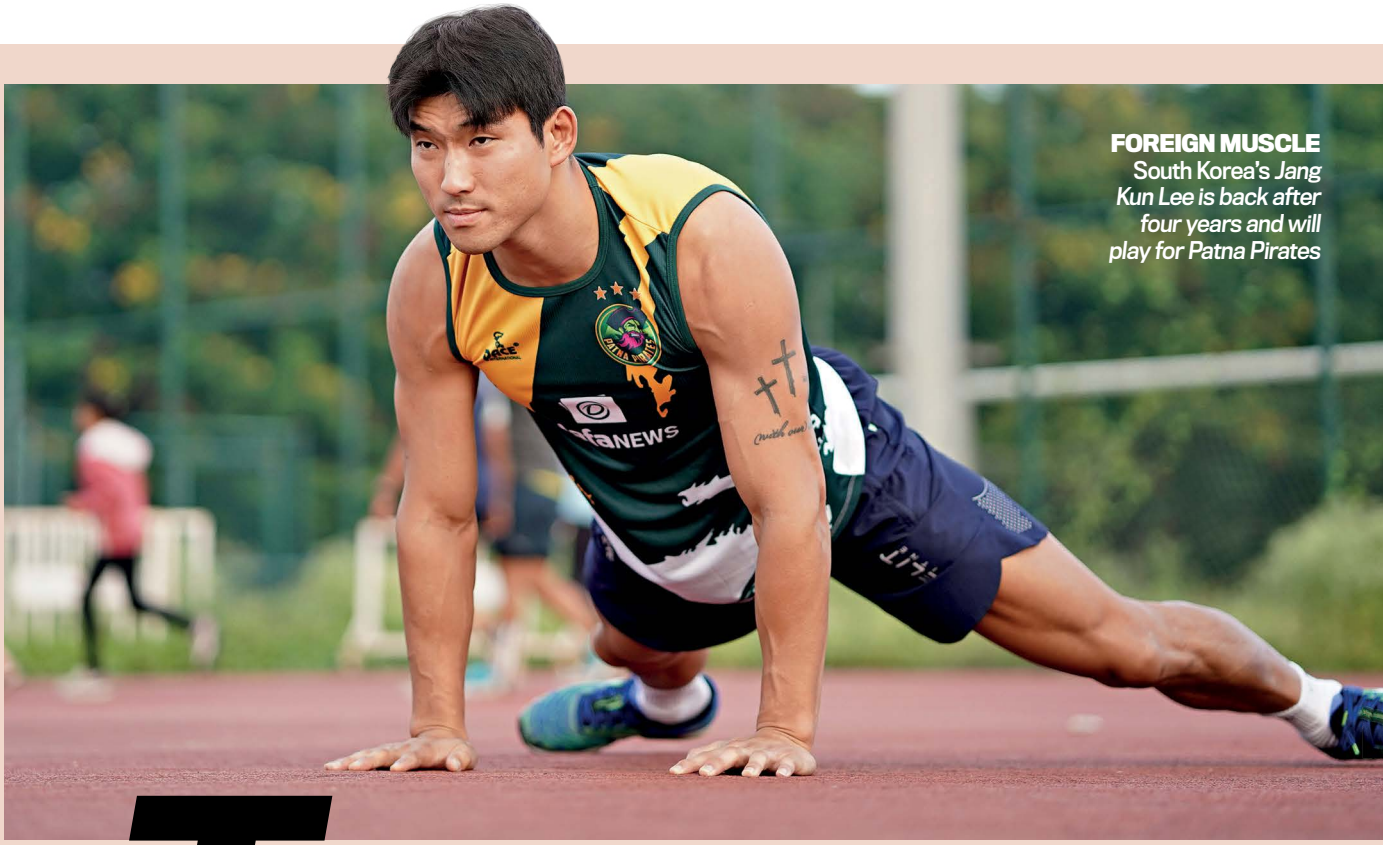


FOREIGN MUSCLE
South Korea's *Jang Kun Lee is back after four years and will play for Patna Pirates*

These days, Sachin Tanwar is used to his friends calling him a crorepati. As the most expensive player in the Pro Kabaddi League (PKL) this season, which begins on October 18 in Hyderabad, the bid of Rs 2.15 crore—the second highest in PKL history—was a culmination of a dream for the Tamil Thalaivas player. "After playing for six years in the league, I had wanted to go to the auction. It was my mother's dream *ki meri sabse best boli lagni chahiye* [I should have the best bid]," he says. Now in its eleventh season, PKL has become one of Star Sports' most successful properties, which it created in collaboration with Mashal Sports a decade back. And in being so, PKL has changed the lives of talented players like Sachin. "I belong to a simple *kisaan* [farmer] family. I couldn't give them much before," he says. "I've made a house for my parents, got a car for my father and brother. It feels good to help them."

As part of the second most popular sporting league in India after the Indian Premier League, Tanwar has seen not just financial growth but also seen kabaddi evolve at a rapid rate. "Now kabaddi is something different altogether," he says. Transitioning "from *mitti* to mat, the game's become so fast, the movements are quick and the atmosphere is different." It's this very speed of play which has made PKL ideal for television.

The 25-year-old raider from Haryana is most looking forward to facing his former Gujarat Giants teammate Sunil, who is the most expensive defender this season with a bidding of Rs 1.015 crore and also captain of the U Mumba team. Sunil is glad that big bucks are also being spent on defenders, who tend to be overlooked for the raiders but who, much like the forwards in football, do most of the scoring. "For a team to win, *defence ka strong hona bahut zaroori hai* [it's important to have a good defence]," he says. "If we don't do well, then points are conceded. How much can a raider do?" With ace defender Parvesh Bhainswal and Iran's Amirmohamed Zafardanesh, a top raider, also in their fold, U Mumba will be hoping to end the drought, having last won the title in 2015.

The latest iteration of PKL will once again see 12 teams. While Indian players dominate the league, it will also feature 17 Iranians and another four imports from South Korea, Taiwan, Bangladesh and Thailand. Earlier editions have seen players from England, Kenya, Japan and Indonesia, further cementing the global appeal of the league. There's nothing lost in translation on the mat, for kabaddi has its own language, notes Sunil. "Bonus, touch point, ankle hold, corner cover, dive... everyone follows it," he adds, citing the terms. Sunil, in fact, has already begun discussing tactics over Zoom with U Mumba coach Gholamreza Mazandarani, an Iranian who led his country to a historic gold at the 2018 Asian Games where they upset India

While Indian players will dominate, **THIS EDITION OF PKL** will feature 17 Iranians and a player each from S. Korea, Thailand, Taiwan and Bangladesh